

Ukulele Songwriter's Guide

The ukulele is a great songwriting instrument. The most famous pop progression, **C – G – Am – F**, uses four of the easiest chords on it.

Your home key: C. Use the key of C for Song 1. The key of G also works well on ukulele if a song sits better for your voice there.

How to read the chord shapes

Four numbers, one for each string, in the order you hold the ukulele: **G – C – E – A** (top string to bottom string).

- **0** = open string (no finger)
- **2** = press at the 2nd fret

Example: **Am = 2000** → 2nd fret on the G string, everything else open.

Key of C chords (Song 1)

Chord	Number	Shape (G C E A)	Difficulty
C	I	0003	easy
Dm	ii	2210	easy
Em	iii	0432	medium
F	IV	2010	easy
G	V	0232	easy
Am	vi	2000	easy

The hit-song loop: C (0003) → G (0232) → Am (2000) → F (2010)

Smooth-change tip: going from Am (2000) to F (2010), keep your 2nd-fret finger down and just add one finger. Look for fingers that can stay put when you change chords.

Key of G chords (optional)

Chord	Number	Shape (G C E A)
G	I	0232
Am	ii	2000
Bm	iii	4222 (barre, harder)
C	IV	0003
D	V	2220
Em	vi	0432

Phase 2 chords (Session 7)

In the key of C:

- Fm (iv, bittersweet) = **1013**
- B^b (bVII, triumphant) = **3211** (1st-fret barre across the bottom two strings)
- A^b (bVI, cinematic) = **1343**
- E (III, pulls to Am) = **1402**, or the easier E7 = **1202**

In the key of G:

- Cm (iv) = **0333**
- F (bVII) = **2010**
- E^b (bVI) = **0331**
- B7 (instead of B, pulls to Em) = **2322**

Color chords (smooth, lo-fi sound): Am7 = **0000** (just strum the open strings), Cmaj7 = **0002**, Dm7 = **2213**, Fmaj7 = **2410**

Strum patterns = chord rhythm

These match the chord rhythms in Song Lab and the Beat Patterns handout. D = down strum, U = up strum, **X** = chuck.

1. Whole notes (ballad)

Count: 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &
Strum: D

2. Quarters (driving)

Count: 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &
Strum: D . D . D . D .

3. The push (modern pop)

Count: 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &
Strum: D . . D . . .

Strum on 1, then again on the "&" of 2, and let it ring.

4. Island strum (classic ukulele)

Count: 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &
Strum: D . D U . U D U

Keep your hand moving down-up the whole time, even when you miss the strings.

5. The chuck (the ukulele's built-in snare drum)

Count: 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &
Strum: D . X . D U X .

How to chuck: strum down and land the side of your palm on the strings right away, muting them with a percussive "chk." Putting the chuck on beats 2 and 4 is exactly where the snare goes. It makes a solo ukulele sound like a band.

Finding melody notes on the ukulele

The ukulele's top G string is tuned **high** (called "re-entrant" tuning), so the **lowest note is the open C string: middle C**. That means ukulele melodies sit right on the treble staff,

perfect for おんぷノート.

Notes of the C major scale, first five frets:

- **C string:** open = C (middle C) · 2 = D · 4 = E · 5 = F
- **E string:** open = E · 1 = F · 3 = G
- **A string:** open = A · 2 = B · 3 = C · 5 = D
- **G string (high G):** open = G · 2 = A · 4 = B · 5 = C

Scale path, low to high: C string 0, 2, 4 → E string 1, 3 → A string 0, 2, 3 = **C D E F G A B C**

Hum a note, then hunt for it on this path. Write down the letter name, then put it in おんぷノート.

What the ukulele can't do: bass

Because of the high G string, the ukulele has no low notes. For basslines (Session 8):

1. Find the bass note's **letter name** on the ukulele (the chord's root).
 2. Play it on a GarageBand **Bass** or **Keyboard** track, down low.
 3. Or use GarageBand's Smart Bass and tap the chord strips.
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Recording your ukulele in GarageBand

A real ukulele track makes the song sound like **you**.

1. **Tune first.** GarageBand has a built-in tuner, or use a free tuner app.
2. Add an **Audio Recorder** track.
3. **Headphones on**, metronome on.
4. **Mic placement:** about 15–20 cm away, pointed at where the neck meets the body (not straight into the sound hole, which sounds boomy).
5. Record 3 takes. Keep the steadiest one.
6. Mistake in one bar? Record just that section again.

Ukulele as the lead: don't want to sing? Pluck the melody on the ukulele and record it as the lead track.

Ukulele songwriting tricks

- **Capo** (if you have one): clip it on the 2nd fret and play the same C-shapes. The song moves up to the key of D, handy if the melody is too low for your voice.
- **Riff from a chord:** hold a chord shape and pluck its strings one at a time in a pattern. Instant intro riff.
- **Stop-time:** in the pre-chorus, strum once per bar and mute. Then burst into the full strum on the chorus.
- **Two ukulele parts:** record strummed chords, then a second track of plucked notes. Pan them slightly apart.